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The India Today Conclave is being held at a time when the world's biggest democratic festival is about to begin. Today, when the whole world is caught in a whirlpool of uncertainty, one thing is certain, that India will continue to grow at a fast pace. Today, the mood of the nation is about making India the third largest economy in the world. Today, the mood of the nation is to build a Viksit Bharat.

Whenever I come to such a conclave, I am expected to leave you with a lot of headlines. However, I am someone who works not for headlines but deadlines. And this is why today I would like to talk of things that the media doesn't find attractive. The media may not like to touch them but these are issues that touch the common man. Start-ups, for instance. Ten years ago, there were very few start-ups, hardly 100. Today, there are around 1.25 lakh registered start-ups. **But India's start-up revolution is not recognised only by numbers, the real strength lies in the fact that these start-ups are in more than 600 districts of India—in a way, 90 per cent of the country's area.** This is a big achievement in itself. Otherwise, people think start-up means Bengaluru. But the youth in Tier 2 and Tier 3 cities are leading the start-up revolution. And those [Opposition parties] that never discussed start-ups are now forced to talk about start-ups.

It is also very important to talk about a scheme that is bringing a huge change in jobs and self-employment on the ground. The Mudra Yojana. In our country, to get help from banks, the youth had to give several guarantees in several places. But thanks to the Mudra scheme, youngsters who do not have any guarantee can also get bank loans. **Without any guarantee, Rs 26 lakh crore in bank loans has been disbursed to small entrepreneurs. Of these, 80 million Mudra beneficiaries are those who have started businesses for the first time in their lives.**

PM SVANidhi is another such scheme, through which street vendors, for the first time, got cheap and easy loans, without any guarantees. My life experiences inspired me to start this scheme. **I have witnessed the richness of the poor and the poverty of the rich. That's why I found the courage to give street vendors loans without any guarantee.** Remember how, during Covid, life came to a halt without these street vendors. That day, I had decided that they are a true force, I will do something for them.

I appreciate them because of the way they have adopted Digital India. Those who were insulted as illiterate are today the face of India's digital revolution. The world talks about India's digital revolution because when embassies here receive guests from their countries, they go to these street vendors, buy something from them and show their compatriots how they can do with